

Bengal: Environment and Culture

How Nature Shaped the Way People of Bengal Lived, Believed, and Organised Their Lives?

Everything about Bengal's culture — its gods, its food, its clothing, its houses, its markets, and even its folk stories — can be traced back to one source: its environment. Bangladesh is a delta. It is defined by water, monsoon, fertile soil, rivers, and forests. This document explores how that environment shaped the cultural life of Bengal's people across six key areas. The core argument is simple: you cannot understand Bangladeshi culture without first understanding Bangladeshi nature.

1. Water: The Most Powerful Force in Bengali Culture

Of all the environmental forces that shaped Bengali culture, water is the most important. Bangladesh has one of the densest river networks in the world. The monsoon brings enormous volumes of rain every year. Rivers flood, they provide fish, they carry boats, they connect villages. It is no surprise, then, that water became sacred.

Water in Hindu culture

In the Hindu tradition of Bengal, both Goddess Durga and the River Ganga are called 'Ma' (mother) — the eternal provider and protector. Hindu fishermen pray to Ma Ganga not just for a good catch but for physical safety on the water. The annual ritual dip at Langalband, where the Ganga and Brahmaputra meet near Dhaka, draws thousands of people. The river is seen as a place where sins are washed away, not just bodies.

Water in Muslim culture

When Islam arrived in Bengal, it did not erase this relationship with water — it adapted it. Local Muslim communities replaced river goddesses with Islamic equivalents. Khaja Khizr — a mythological 'water-saint' said to be alive since Noah's time — became the protector of fishermen and sailors. Dargahs (shrines of holy men) are almost always located near rivers or water bodies. Muslim fishermen pray, offer shirni (sweetmeats), and visit dargahs before the first fishing voyage of the season.

The specific religious figure changed (goddess → pir → water-saint), but water itself remained at the centre of Bengali spiritual life across all religious traditions. This is a perfect example of how environment shapes culture more deeply than theology does.

2. Climate: How Heat and Humidity Shaped Daily Life

Bengal's hot and humid climate did not just make people uncomfortable — it shaped what they ate, what they wore, how they built their houses, and even when they got married.

Health and the calendar

The month of Bhadra (mid-August to mid-September) was dreaded. A 19th-century English doctor, William Twining, noted that about one-quarter of annual deaths in Bengal occurred in this single month due to extreme heat, humidity, and disease. People avoided travel, reduced food intake, and ate cooling foods like unripe coconut water and jute-leaf infusions. Marriages were not arranged in this month. These are not superstitions — they are rational adaptations to a dangerous climate, developed over centuries of observation.

Example: Even today, most rural communities in Bangladesh prefer to hold weddings in the cooler, drier winter months (November–February) when food is plentiful and travel is easy. This practice is thousands of years old.

Clothing and textiles

Bengal became world-famous for its muslin — an extremely fine, lightweight cotton fabric. This was not an accident. Cotton is the best fabric for hot, humid weather. The shari, dhuti, and punjabi-pajama — all made of light cotton — became the standard dress for Bengali men and women across all religious communities. The demand for cotton clothing, rooted in climate, directly gave rise to a major textile industry that employed weavers from Hindu, Muslim, and indigenous traditions alike.

A cultural product as specific as 'what Bengalis wear' is directly explained by climate. Culture is not invented randomly — it is a practical response to the environment people live in.

3. Housing: Building for a Deltaic Environment

How people build their homes reflects the environment they live in. In Bengal, three environmental realities shaped housing: heat and humidity (needing ventilation), flooding (needing elevation), and the availability of bamboo and mud (cheap, local materials).

Bamboo, mud, and ventilation

The ordinary peasant house in eastern Bengal was made of split bamboo with a thatched roof. Bamboo naturally allows air to circulate, which was crucial in the humid climate. In contrast, western Bengal had more masonry (brick and mortar) buildings — but these were poorly ventilated and led to more disease. Eastern Bengal's bamboo houses were actually healthier. Houses were also typically raised on posts above the ground because the deltaic soil was always damp — sitting directly on wet ground caused illness. Bengali peasants understood this intuitively, even without modern medicine.

Trees around the homestead

Homes in eastern Bengal were characteristically surrounded by fruit trees, banana plants, and thick thatch. This was not just for beauty. Trees provided food, fuel, and privacy. They also created shade and cooling airflow around the house. This intimacy between the home and its natural surroundings reflects a deep cultural relationship with nature — the house was not separate from the environment but embedded within it.

Example: This tradition of the 'bari' — a homestead surrounded by trees, garden, and water — remains visible in rural Bangladesh today and is a direct product of centuries of environmental adaptation.

4. Forests: The Cultural World of the Sundarbans

For most cultures, the forest represents the unknown and the threatening. In Bengali culture, the forest is something more complex — simultaneously dangerous and sacred, alien and familiar. The Sundarbans, the world's largest mangrove forest, is the clearest example of this.

Bonobibi: the forest goddess

People who entered the Sundarbans to collect honey, timber, or fish faced real danger from tigers and snakes. To navigate this danger, they created Bonobibi — a forest goddess with a syncretic identity. She was said to have been raised by deer 'by the will of Allah,' making her acceptable to both Hindu and Muslim communities. Before entering the forest, communities performed rituals invoking her protection. The gunin — a ritual specialist — would accompany forest-goers with spells and amulets.

Key insight: Bonobibi is worshipped by both Hindus and Muslims. She is a goddess with Islamic phrases in her origin story. This is not confusion — it is Bengal's famous cultural syncretism at work, produced directly by the shared environment that all communities depended on, regardless of religion.

The forest as an ethical space

In Bengali folk imagination, the forest is not just a physical place — it is a moral testing ground. If a group entered the forest with impure intentions and was attacked by a tiger, the attack was explained as divine punishment. The forest thus became a place where ethics, nature, and spirituality converged. This worldview — unique to deltaic cultures — shows how deeply the environment shaped not just practical life but moral thinking.

5. Markets, Mobility, and the River Economy

Bengal's population has always been mobile. The rivers made movement easy and natural. This shaped not just trade but the entire social and cultural character of the delta.

Floating markets and river bazaars

In Bengal, the bazaar (market) was almost always located near a river or water body. Richard Temple, a British Lieutenant Governor of Bengal who visited eastern Bengal in the 1870s, described a remarkable sight: thousands of boats moored together forming what he called 'a floating city' — with merchants, goods, and transactions all happening on the water. Markets would form, trade would be conducted, and then the flotilla would dissolve and reform elsewhere. This was not an occasional event — it was the standard form of commerce in Bengal for centuries.

Bengal as a trade crossroads

The Bengal delta was never isolated. Its rivers connected it to the interior of South Asia, while its sea coast opened it to the Indian Ocean. From ancient times, Bengal traded with Arabia, China, South East Asia, Sri Lanka, and eventually Europe. In the coastal waterways of Bengal, South East Asians, Arabs, Chinese, Central Asians, Ethiopians, and Tibetans all met. The famous Moroccan traveller Ibn Battuta, visiting in 1346, arrived in Bengal from Sri Lanka and left on a Chinese ship bound for Java — a perfect illustration of how central Bengal was to global trade networks. This openness to the world was made possible by Bengal's geography.

Example: The earliest coins found in ancient Bengali cities like Chandraketugarh had pictures of boats stamped on them — showing that water-based trade was central to Bengal's identity from the very beginning of its urban civilization.

6. When the Environment Declines: Culture Suffers Too

The relationship between environment and culture works in both directions. When nature thrives, culture is rich and diverse. When the environment is damaged, culture loses its depth and people lose their livelihoods. This is not a distant future concern — it is happening in Bangladesh right now.

What has been lost

Bengal once had over 6,000 varieties of local rice, each suited to specific soils, climates, and seasons. The poet Jasimuddin wrote of 'binni dhaner khoi' — a special parched rice made from the binni variety. Today, due to industrial monoculture farming (HYV or High Yield Variety rice), only about 100 rice varieties survive. This is not just a loss of biodiversity — it is a loss of cultural vocabulary. A poet today cannot write meaningfully about binni rice because the variety barely exists.

The human consequences

- Arsenic contamination now affects 70% of Bangladesh's underground water, putting 40 million people at risk.
- Monga — a seasonal near-famine in northern Bangladesh caused by drought and riverbank erosion — leaves hundreds of thousands without food or work every year between July and November.

- Rural populations are migrating to cities in large numbers, not by choice but because environmental collapse has destroyed their livelihoods.
- Ecological disruptions have contributed to unemployment (30–35%), landlessness, and urban overcrowding.
- Climate change, combined with colonial-era infrastructure (railways, embankments) that disrupted natural river flow, has accelerated this decline.

Key insight: Environmental decline is not a separate topic from cultural or political history. When the environment that produced Bengali culture is destroyed, the culture itself begins to hollow out. This is why inclusive history always treats ecology as a primary subject, not a background detail.

Summary: Environment → Culture (At a Glance)

Environmental Force	Cultural / Social Response
Monsoon and rivers	Water became sacred — goddesses, pirs, shrines near rivers
Hot, humid climate	Light cotton clothing, cooling foods, seasonal health practices
Deltaic floodplain soil	Houses on raised posts, bamboo construction, cross-ventilation
Forests (Sundarbans)	Forest goddesses (Bonobibi), gunin (ritual guides), ethics of the wild
River-based mobility	Bazaars built near water, floating markets, boat culture
Rich biodiversity	Indigenous farming techniques, medicinal plant knowledge, 6,000 rice varieties
Climate change today	Monga (near-famine), rural exodus, social unrest, loss of cultural vocabulary

Conclusion: Nature Made Bengali Culture

The central argument of this lecture is straightforward: Bengali culture is not an accident and it did not come from theology or politics alone. It grew directly from the environment that people lived in — a vast, flat, warm, wet delta, cut through by hundreds of rivers, subject to monsoon floods, covered partly by ancient forests, and connected to the world by sea.

The monsoon made water sacred. The heat made cotton universal. The wet soil made bamboo homes rational. The Sundarbans made forest goddesses necessary. The rivers made markets mobile. The rich biodiversity made indigenous knowledge sophisticated. Every element of culture can be traced back to an environmental cause.

Bengal was also uniquely positioned at the meeting point of South Asia, South East Asia, and the Indian Ocean world. This location made it a crossroads for people, goods, ideas, and religions. Instead of being dominated by any one cultural tradition, Bengal absorbed and blended all of them — Hindu, Buddhist, Islamic, animist, indigenous — producing the remarkably syncretic, layered, and flexible culture that we recognize as distinctly Bengali.

Finally, this lecture asks students to recognize that this culture is now under threat. Environmental degradation is not a technical problem — it is a cultural and historical crisis. Protecting Bangladesh's ecology means protecting the conditions that make Bengali culture possible. History, ecology, and culture are inseparable.

Based on: Iftekhar Iqbal, 'Environment and Culture'